P.R.S. OBEROI (1929-2023)

A Titan Checks Out

A contemporary legend, Biki Oberoi crafted Indian hospitality's stunning response to the world

By Aman Nath

As tributes come flying in from all over the cyber skies, there is a momentary darkness over India. But I am sure that P.R.S. 'Biki' Oberoi would have liked it otherwise. When the tomorrow to this sorrow comes, there will be even more light.

When his father Rai Bahadur Mohan Singh Oberoi had fled a virulent plague in Lahore to arrive in Simla, the summer capital of British India, he did not know that he was propelling his destiny to the skies. Starting from a monthly salary of Rs 50 as the front desk clerk at the Cecil Hotel, his success in business—where he turned each challenge into an opportunity—saw this common Punjabi surname metamorphose into a chic, aspirational brand flaunted in the highest echelons of society, one that is a byword for entrepreneurship. He also made ordinary Indians connoisseurs. Today, as the second-generation stalwart of the Oberoi Hotels passes away, its annual revenues touch Rs 2,096 crore (in FY23).



It can't be a coincidence that today, a majority of the heads of all hotel chains in India have been trained at the Oberoi Centre of Learning and Development. Together, they have turned India's bundle of inferiority complexes into a loud hooray! The complexes, born of colonialism, began to evaporate when the Oberoi Group founder began his foray at the Clarkes Hotel in Simla. But under his son, Biki Oberoi, our frayed psyche, which was first darned at the edges, soared to newer heights, as the world came and marvelled at India's potential and capabilities in the Delhi of 1965, just as they had done under the vision of Sir J.N. Tata in the Bombay of 1904. Imperial arrogance had been dealt a blow as India stood upright and ready to win ever more laurels.

Biki Oberoi was not a very tall man, but he became a little-big man, like Napoleon or Aristotle Onassis and a host of other stalwarts, titans of their fields looked up to by an awestruck world. He once told me how the Maharaja of Jaipur had taken longer than was the customary etiquette to see him for an appointment. Biki had wanted to discuss turning Jaigarh Fort into an ultimate dream hotel. But he had left mildly offended and decided to create the Raj Vilas in Jaipur, which was much ahead of its time. It was eventually to become more royal than royal lifestyles, which had been considerably dented after the Privy Purses were abolished.

A contemporary legend is someone with whom every encounter is later narrated as a remarkable or life-changing story. Biki Oberoi was certainly old gold, of remarkable mettle. The Rani of Sarila related to me over lunch recently that when a girl from east India brought her bed tea in her room at the Oberoi, New Delhi, she was surprised to see her radiant, orange lipstick, which made her day. "Did you choose the lipstick that you wear?" she asked her out of curiosity. "No madam, it was Mr Oberoi's choice," came the answer. Two days later, she checked with Biki Oberoi when she bumped into him at the spa where he was working with his team. "Yes, it was my choice," he said, laughing a lot. "Now that is a detail you wouldn't expect the creator of a world-class chain to be looking into," she says in admiration.

When Rajasthan Tourism finally decided to get serious about its potential, a closed-door meeting was held at The Ashok in Jaipur, headed by the minister of tourism and attended by just five people. Mr Oberoi and I were both present. The minister began with, "I want to give you the good news that this year Jaisalmer had so many tourists that people put up tents on the rooftops to house them...." "With all due respect to you, madam minister, this is not tourism," interrupted Mr Oberoi. "We must plan ahead and create hotels at such destinations so that each visitor carries amazing memories after having paid many hundred dollars!" The silence after Biki Oberoi spoke belonged only to him. ■

Aman Nath is a writer, hotelier, architectural restorer and founder & chairman of the Neemrana Hotels chain